

ARACHIS ONLINE TRAINING

Traditional Maheu Formula (20 Litres)

A beginner-friendly training guide suitable for Zimbabwean small business production.

WHAT IS MAHEU?

Maheu is a fermented non-alcoholic drink commonly made from maize meal. It is popular in Zimbabwe because:

- * It is cheap to produce
- * Ingredients are easy to find
- * It has high demand
- * It can be sold in cups, bottles, or sachets
- * It is filling and refreshing

You can start small from home and grow into a real beverage business.

EQUIPMENT NEEDED

- * 25L bucket or container
- * Large cooking pot
- * Wooden stick or spoon
- * Stove/fire source
- * Measuring cups
- * Strainer (optional)
- * Bottles or containers for packaging

INGREDIENTS FOR 20 LITRES

Ingredient	Quantity
Maize meal (roller meal or refined mealie meal)	2 kg
Water	20 litres
Sugar	1.5 – 2 kg
Wheat flour (optional for thickness)	200 g
Maheu starter culture OR plain sour maheu	500 ml
Salt	1 teaspoon
Flavour/essence (banana, vanilla, strawberry etc.)	Optional
Preservative (sodium benzoate)	10 g optional

UNDERSTANDING THE INGREDIENTS

1. Maize Meal

This is the main ingredient. It gives the drink body, taste, and thickness.

Best types:

- * Roller meal
- * Refined mealie meal

Avoid:

- * Very coarse mealie meal because it becomes rough.

2. Sugar

Sugar improves taste and also slightly supports fermentation.

You can reduce sugar for a cheaper product.

3. Starter Culture

This is what makes the maheu sour and fermented.

You can use:

- * Already fermented maheu
- * Plain maheu from previous batch
- * Commercial maheu starter

Without this, fermentation will be slow.

4. Sodium Benzoate (Optional)

This helps increase shelf life.

It is useful if:

- * You want to sell commercially
- * You want the drink to last longer

STEP-BY-STEP PROCEDURE

STEP 1 — MAKE THE PORRIDGE

In a bucket:

Mix:

- * 2 kg maize meal
- * Small amount of cold water

Make a smooth paste with no lumps.

STEP 2 — BOIL WATER

Boil about 15 litres of water.

Slowly pour the boiling water into the maize paste while stirring continuously.

This prevents lumps.

STEP 3 — COOK THE MIXTURE

Transfer to a large pot.

Cook for:

- * 20–30 minutes

Stir regularly.

This removes raw maize taste.

STEP 4 — COOL THE MIXTURE

Allow the porridge to cool until:

- * Warm but not hot

IMPORTANT:

If it is too hot it will kill the fermentation bacteria.

STEP 5 — ADD SUGAR

Add:

- * 1.5–2 kg sugar
- * Salt

Mix thoroughly.

STEP 6 — ADD STARTER CULTURE

Add:

- * 500 ml sour maheu or starter

Mix well.

STEP 7 — FERMENTATION

Cover the container.

Leave for:

- * 12–24 hours

Best fermentation temperature:

- * Warm room temperature

Longer fermentation:

- * More sour taste

Shorter fermentation:

- * Sweeter taste

HOW TO KNOW IT IS READY

The maheu should:

- * Smell slightly sour
- * Taste smooth

- * Have mild fermentation taste
- * Not smell rotten

STEP 8 — ADD FLAVOUR (OPTIONAL)

You may add:

- * Banana flavour
- * Vanilla
- * Strawberry
- * Cream soda flavour

This helps differentiate your brand.

STEP 9 — ADD PRESERVATIVE (OPTIONAL)

Dissolve:

- * 10 g sodium benzoate

In warm water first.

Then mix into the maheu.

STEP 10 — PACKAGE

Package into:

- * 500 ml bottles
- * 1 litre bottles
- * Cups
- * Sachets

Keep refrigerated if possible.

SHELF LIFE

Condition	Shelf Life
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No preservative	1–2 days
With preservative + refrigeration	5–7 days

COST REDUCTION TIPS

To lower production cost:

- * Reduce sugar slightly
- * Buy maize meal in bulk
- * Use reusable containers
- * Produce larger batches

BUSINESS TIPS

1. Packaging matters

Good packaging can allow you to charge more even if competitors are cheaper.

2. Sell cold

Cold maheu sells faster.

3. Start near:

- * Schools
- * Markets
- * Bus stops
- * Construction sites

4. Introduce flavours

Flavoured maheu looks more premium.

COMMON PROBLEMS & SOLUTIONS

Problem	Cause	Solution
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Too sour	Fermented too long	Reduce fermentation time
Too thick	Too much maize meal	Add water
Bad smell	Contamination	Use clean containers
Lumps	Poor mixing	Stir properly
Very watery	Too little maize meal	Increase mealie meal

ESTIMATED SELLING PRICES IN ZIMBABWE

Package	Possible Selling Price
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250 ml cup	\$0.25 – \$0.50
500 ml bottle	\$0.50 – \$1
1 litre	\$1 – \$1.50

Prices depend on:

- * Packaging
- * Location
- * Branding
- * Taste quality

FINAL LESSON

Maheu is not just a drink.

It is a low-capital food business suitable for:

- * Youths
- * Families
- * Small entrepreneurs
- * Market vendors

Consistency, hygiene, branding, and good taste are what build repeat customers.